QP Code: 25900442

MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM MGU-UGP (HONOURS) Regular EXAMINATION October 2025 Third SEMESTER

Value Addition Course (VAC) - MG3VACHIS201 - VALUE AND ETHICS IN ARCHAEOLOGY

Answer Scheme

Part A SHORT ANSWER
Answer any **5** questions Each question carries **2** marks

1. What is the scope of archaeology? [U] / [CO1]Archaeology explores human history through material remains such as tools, pottery, monuments, and settlements. Its scope includes excavation, conservation, dating methods, heritage management, and museum studies. It helps understand past cultures, human evolution, and environmental changes, offering careers in research, teaching, museums, cultural resource management, and heritage conservation.
2. What is the role of UNESCO in archaeological ethics? [K] / [CO1]UNESCO promotes archaeological ethics through global conventions, such as the 1970 Convention against illicit trafficking of cultural property and the 1972 World Heritage Convention. It emphasizes preservation, responsible excavation, cultural heritage protection, international cooperation, and public awareness, ensuring that archaeology respects human history and benefits future generations.
3. What is meant by cultural sensitivity in archaeology? [A] / [CO2]Cultural sensitivity in archaeology means respecting the beliefs, traditions, and values of the communities connected to archaeological sites. It involves seeking consent, avoiding offensive interpretations, protecting sacred spaces, and involving local people in research, ensuring that archaeological practices honour living cultures and their ancestral heritage.
4. Why is site conservation important? [U] / [CO2]Site conservation is vital in archaeology because it protects fragile remains, artifacts, and structures from decay, looting, and destruction. Preserving sites maintains the integrity of historical evidence for future research and education, helps sustain cultural heritage, and ensures that the stories of past civilizations remain accessible to coming generations.
5. What is archaeological tourism? [K] / [CO3]Archaeological tourism involves visiting ancient sites, monuments, and museums to learn about past human civilizations. It promotes cultural understanding, supports heritage conservation, and boosts local economies. Responsible archaeological tourism encourages public awareness and appreciation of history while ensuring that fragile sites and artifacts are preserved for future generations.
6. Give one example of repatriated museum artefact. [U] / [CO3]Repatriated museum artefacts are cultural objects or artworks returned to their country or community of origin after being taken or looted during colonial times or illegal trade. For example, the bronze idol of Goddess Durga Mahishasuramardini was repatriated from the Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York, to India in 2018.
7. Mention one famous case of antiquity repatriation. [U] / [CO4]One famous case of antiquity repatriation is the return of the **Nataraja bronze idol** to India from Australia's National Gallery in 2014. The 900-year-old Chola-period statue was stolen from a temple in Tamil Nadu and illegally sold abroad before being identified and formally returned to India by Australian authorities.
8. Mention one reason for illicit trade of artefacts. [U] / [CO4] One major reason for the illicit trade of artefacts is the high demand for rare antiquities in the international art market. Collectors and dealers often seek unique cultural objects, leading to illegal excavations, theft, and smuggling. Weak heritage laws and lack of site protection further encourage this unlawful trade.

Part BSHORT ESSAY
Answer any **4** questionsEach question carries **5** marks

9. Write a note on antiquarianism and its role in shaping ethicalawareness.[K] / [CO1]
Antiquarianism refers to the early study and collection of ancient objects, monuments, and manuscripts out of curiosity for the past. Though lacking scientific methods, antiquarians laid the foundation for modern archaeology by documenting sites and artefacts. However, their focus on collecting rather than conserving led to site damage and loss of context. The shortcomings of antiquarian practices prompted the development of archaeological ethics, emphasizing responsible excavation, proper documentation, and heritage preservation. Thus, antiquarianism played a crucial role in shaping ethical awareness in archaeology, transforming the discipline from treasure hunting into a scientific and culturally sensitive study of the past.
10.Discuss the role of archaeology in reconstructing past societies. [U] / [CO1]

Archaeology plays a vital role in reconstructing past societies by studying material remains such as tools, pottery, architecture, burials, and art. Through excavation and analysis, archaeologists interpret social organization, economy, religion, and technology. This evidence helps rebuild human history, revealing how ancient communities lived, adapted to environments, and evolved culturally over time.

11. Write a note on the importance of recording and documentation. [U] / [CO1]Recording and documentation are essential in archaeology for preserving information about excavations, sites, and artefacts. Since excavation is a destructive process, accurate records of contexts, layers, and findings ensure that data remains available for future research. Proper documentation through drawings, photographs, notes, and digital databases allows interpretation, comparison, publication, and heritage conservation.

12. Write a note on participatory excavation projects. [U] / [CO2] Participatory excavation projects in archaeology involve local communities, students, and volunteers working alongside professional archaeologists in fieldwork. This inclusive approach promotes public awareness, heritage stewardship, and knowledge sharing. By engaging communities directly connected to sites, such projects encourage cultural pride, transparency, and ethical responsibility, ensuring long-term preservation and sustainable heritage management.

13. Explain the role of communities in decisions about human remains. [U] / [CO3] Communities play a crucial role in decisions about excavating, studying, and displaying human remains. Archaeologists must respect the beliefs, traditions, and values of descendant or local groups connected to the remains. Consulting these communities ensures ethical handling, appropriate reburial, or preservation practices, fostering trust, cultural sensitivity, and shared responsibility in heritage management.

14. Discuss the role of governments in protecting submerged heritage. [U] / [CO3] Governments play a vital role in protecting submerged heritage through legislation, research, and enforcement. They establish laws to regulate underwater excavations, prevent looting, and safeguard shipwrecks and submerged settlements. Agencies support underwater archaeological surveys, collaborate with UNESCO's 2001 Convention, and promote heritage awareness, ensuring scientific preservation and sustainable management of underwater cultural resources.

15. Discuss the ethical implications of deliberate heritage destruction. [K] / [CO4] Deliberate destruction of heritage, whether through war, vandalism, or unplanned development, results in the irreversible loss of valuable evidence about human history. Such acts raise serious ethical concerns as they violate humanity's collective right to cultural identity and memory. Archaeologists view heritage

destruction as a crime against humanity, emphasizing the importance of preservation, documentation, and international cooperation. Protecting cultural heritage is therefore not only a professional duty but also a moral responsibility, ensuring that the achievements and experiences of past societies are respected, remembered, and passed on to future generations for continued learning and intercultural understanding.

[5x4 = 20]

Part CESSAY QUESTION
Answer any **2** questionsEach question carries **10** marks

16. Critically evaluate the importance of ethics in archaeological research. [K] / [CO1] Ethics form the foundation of archaeological research, guiding how the past is explored, interpreted, and preserved. Since archaeology deals with human heritage and cultural identity, ethical responsibility is essential to ensure that research respects both ancient remains and the living communities connected to them. Ethical principles require archaeologists to conduct excavations scientifically, avoid site destruction, and maintain honesty and transparency in research and publication. Mention organizations such as UNESCO, ICOMOS, and the World Archaeological Congress have established ethical codes that stress conservation, community involvement, and the prevention of illicit trade in antiquities. Respect for local beliefs, cultural sensitivities, and proper treatment of human remains are also central to ethical practice.Moreover, ethics encourage collaboration, data sharing, and the open dissemination of knowledge for public benefit. They transform archaeology from a mere quest for discovery into a socially responsible discipline committed to safeguarding cultural heritage. Ethical awareness ensures that the study of the past is carried out with integrity, fairness, and respect, protecting irreplaceable evidence of human history for future generations. Thus, ethics not only preserve the credibility of the discipline but also uphold the moral duty of archaeologists toward humanity's collective past.

17. Analyse how stewardship ensures long-term preservation ofarchaeological sites. [An] / [CO2] Stewardship in archaeology refers to the responsible management and protection of archaeological resources for the benefit of present and future generations. It emphasizes the idea that archaeologists, governments, and communities are caretakers rather than owners of heritage. By promoting sustainable practices, stewardship ensures the long-term preservation of archaeological sites and materials. Effective stewardship involves proper documentation, conservation, and minimal intervention during excavations to prevent damage or loss of information. It encourages collaboration with local communities, fostering awareness and shared responsibility for site protection. Through education and community participation, people learn the value of preserving their heritage, reducing risks of looting, vandalism, and neglect. National and international organizations, such as UNESCO and ICOMOS, support stewardship through heritage laws, training, and management guidelines. Ethical stewardship also includes digital recording, monitoring, and controlled tourism to balance research and conservation needs. Ultimately, stewardship transforms archaeology into a discipline rooted in care and sustainability. It ensures that archaeological sites remain protected, accessible, and meaningful for future research, education, and cultural identity. By treating the past as a shared inheritance, stewardship upholds archaeology's ethical duty to safeguard human history for generations to come.

18. Discuss the consequences of neglecting ethics in fieldwork. [U] / [CO3] Neglecting ethics in archaeological fieldwork can lead to serious and lasting consequences. Unethical practices such as careless excavation, inadequate documentation, or unauthorized removal of artefacts destroy valuable

contextual information that can never be recovered. This loss weakens the scientific value of discoveries and distorts interpretations of the past.Ignoring community rights or cultural sensitivities can also damage relationships with local populations, leading to mistrust and resistance toward future archaeological projects. Furthermore, unethical handling of human remains or sacred sites disrespects cultural beliefs and violates international ethical standards established by UNESCO and ICOMOS. Illicit trade and looting, often fueled by unethical field practices, result in the permanent loss of heritage to private collectors and black markets. Such actions tarnish the reputation of archaeology as a scientific and socially responsible discipline. Therefore, adherence to ethical principles ensures that archaeological research maintains its credibility, promotes cultural respect, and preserves the integrity of historical evidence for future generations. Responsible fieldwork not only safeguards sites but also strengthens the discipline's moral foundation, transforming archaeology into a field dedicated to truth, preservation, and shared human heritage.

19. Critically examine ethical challenges in teaching archaeology. [A] / [CO4]Teaching archaeology presents several ethical challenges that require careful consideration to maintain academic integrity and professional responsibility. As archaeology deals with human heritage, educators must ensure that teaching methods promote respect for past cultures, responsible research practices, and awareness of the discipline's social and moral obligations. One major challenge lies in balancing theoretical knowledge with practical field training. Students must be taught excavation and documentation techniques without causing harm to archaeological sites. Educators also face the ethical duty of discouraging looting, illegal collecting, and misuse of artefacts, emphasizing instead the importance of preservation and community engagement. Handling sensitive topics such as human remains, colonial histories, and indigenous rights requires cultural sensitivity and inclusivity. Teachers must also ensure that diverse perspectives are represented, avoiding Eurocentric or biased interpretations of the past. Additionally, plagiarism, data manipulation, and unequal credit in research collaborations are ethical issues that must be addressed through proper academic guidance. Ultimately, teaching archaeology ethically prepares students to become responsible professionals who value heritage conservation, honesty, and cultural respect. By integrating ethical reflection into every aspect of education, archaeology evolves into a discipline that not only studies the past but also upholds humanity's shared moral and cultural responsibility.